



# Product Design & UX Principles

Week 2 • Day 3 • Strategic Design & Metrics

TPM Academy



## Day 3 Objectives

- Use **Nielsen's 10 heuristics** as a shared vocabulary with designers
- Add three **TPM-specific lenses**: time-to-first-value, failure-mode dignity, power-user respect
- Run an **A11y floor audit** in 20 minutes — the non-negotiable accessibility checks for any TPM
- Audit a real product surface and rank findings by severity
- Convert audit findings into **3 design principles** a squad can hold the line on



# Today's Shape

| Clock         | Block                           | Outcome                                      |
|---------------|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| 09:00 – 09:15 | Opening                         | What product surface is your triad auditing? |
| 09:15 – 10:30 | Block 1 + Activity 1            | Heuristic Hunt                               |
| 10:45 – 12:00 | Block 2 + Activity 2            | A11y Floor Audit                             |
| 13:00 – 14:15 | Block 3 + Activity 3            | Heuristic Audit (your surface)               |
| 14:30 – 16:00 | Block 4 + Activity 4 + Readouts | 3 Design Principles                          |

# Block 1 — The Shared Vocabulary

Nielsen's 10, plus three TPM lenses

# Why TPMs Need This Vocabulary

Designers and engineers will both override your reaction with their craft language. The TPM job is to **name what's wrong in the language they will accept**, then defend why it matters with metrics.

## Without vocabulary

*"This screen feels weird. Can we redo it?"*

Loses the conversation in 30 seconds.

## With vocabulary

*"This screen violates Nielsen #5 (error prevention) and #6 (recognition over recall). The cost shows up in our reconcile-abandonment signal."*

Wins the conversation.



# Nielsen's 10 Heuristics

| #  | Heuristic                   | One-line                                                          |
|----|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Visibility of system status | The user always knows what just happened and what's happening now |
| 2  | Match real world            | Use the user's words, not the system's                            |
| 3  | User control & freedom      | Undo, exit, escape — always                                       |
| 4  | Consistency & standards     | Same word, same color, same place                                 |
| 5  | Error prevention            | Make destructive actions hard, not easy                           |
| 6  | Recognition over recall     | Show options, don't make me remember them                         |
| 7  | Flexibility & efficiency    | Beginners get hand-holding, experts get shortcuts                 |
| 8  | Aesthetic & minimalist      | Every screen element earns its place                              |
| 9  | Recover from errors         | The error message names the field and the fix                     |
| 10 | Help & documentation        | Findable, in-context, searchable                                  |



# Three TPM-Specific Lenses

## 11. Time-to-first-value

Can a new user produce a useful result in their first session? Measured in minutes, not features.

## 12. Failure-mode dignity

How does the product behave when the network drops, the data is wrong, or the user is rushed? Failure is part of UX.

## 13. Power-user respect

Does the product reward repeat use with shortcuts, or punish it with the same friction every time?

**Why these three:** they're the heuristics designers most often skip in early-stage products and most often blame on engineering later.

# Activity 1 — Heuristic Hunt

Triads • 35 minutes

Walk through a B2B SaaS none of your triad uses (provided link). Each member silently captures 3 heuristic violations.

- Pool and de-dupe
- Identify the **most painful** + **most subtle** violation
- Prepare a 60-second readout naming the heuristic numbers



5 min solo • 10 min pool • 10 min cull • 5 min readout prep

# Block 2 — The A11y Floor

The 8 checks every TPM should run before any PRD ships



## Why a Floor, Not a Ceiling

Accessibility is a **regulatory floor** (ADA, Section 508, EAA), an **SEO floor**, and a **usability ceiling**. Fixes for keyboard-only users almost always fix mouse-user errors too.

**The TPM responsibility:** not to be the a11y expert, but to refuse to ship a feature that fails the floor — and to spot failures unsolicited.



# The 8-Check Floor

| Check                            | Tool                    | Fail looks like               |
|----------------------------------|-------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Keyboard-focusable interactives  | Tab through the page    | Focus disappears              |
| Visible focus indicator          | Tab through the page    | No outline on focus           |
| Color contrast 4.5:1             | WebAIM contrast checker | Light gray on white           |
| Form fields have labels          | Screen reader / inspect | "Edit text, blank"            |
| Images have alt text             | View source             | Empty alt on meaningful image |
| Logical heading hierarchy        | Outline tool            | Jumps h1 → h4                 |
| Errors identify the field        | Submit broken form      | "Error" with no field         |
| Touch targets $\geq 44\text{px}$ | Mobile devtools         | Buttons too small             |

## Activity 2 — A11y Floor Audit

Triads • 40 minutes

Run the 8-check floor on the FieldPulse mobile or your chosen surface. Split the checks across triad members so all 8 are covered (plus one overlap).

- Each fail: which UX heuristic is also being violated?
- Output: one-page **A11y Floor Audit** for the surface



25 min audit · 10 min cross-link to heuristics · 5 min summarize

# Block 3 — Audit Your Surface

Apply the calibrated eye + the floor to the triad's chosen flow



# The Audit Template

- **Top 3 violations** with heuristic + observation + cost + severity (1–5)
- **Top 3 strengths** — what does this product do better than the average B2B SaaS?
- **A11y Floor Audit result** (Pass / Partial / Fail)
- **TPM Lens findings**: time-to-first-value, failure-mode dignity, power-user respect
- **One question** you cannot answer without the design team

**Strengths matter:** a "kill list" of violations alienates designers. Naming what works builds trust to address what doesn't.



## Severity Scoring (1–5)

| Score | Meaning                                  | Example                                                   |
|-------|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| 5     | User task failure or data loss           | "Submit" button unlabeled — user can't complete reconcile |
| 4     | Recurring frustration; users work around | Date picker requires 5 taps — users keep paper logs       |
| 3     | Slows users; stopwatch would notice      | Tab order skips "amount" — users mouse over               |
| 2     | Cosmetic; affects trust                  | Inconsistent button styling                               |
| 1     | Edge case                                | Tooltip cut off in landscape                              |

# Activity 3 — Heuristic Audit of Your Surface

Triads • 40 minutes

Use the audit template on your triad's chosen flow. Severity-score each violation. Capture strengths.

- 10 min: solo walk-through (each member captures 3+ findings)
- 15 min: pool + score severity
- 10 min: write up the template (top 3 violations + strengths)
- 5 min: name the one question only design can answer



10 solo • 15 pool • 10 write • 5 question

# Block 4 — From Audit to Principles

The keeper artifact: 3 design principles your squad can hold the line on

# What a Design Principle Looks Like

A design principle is a **statement**, not a feature. It is **decision-making** — when two options compete, the principle picks one.

## ✓ Good

### Why

"If a dispatcher can't recover from a mis-tap in 1 second, we built it wrong."

Specific, decision-making, memorable

"Show network state on every screen — assume connectivity is broken."

Names a constraint, drives concrete choices

"Power users get keyboard shortcuts. New users get them visible too."

Resolves a tension explicitly

## ✗ Bad

### Why

"Be user-friendly"

Vacuous

"Use Material Design"

A toolkit, not a principle

"Be consistent"

True but not actionable



## Cull to Three

1. **Cluster audit findings into themes.** Each theme suggests a principle.
2. **Draft 5 candidate principles.** Some will be bad. That's fine.
3. **Test each:** when two options compete, does this tell us what to choose?
4. **Cull to 3.** Three is the limit for memorability.
5. **Write each principle** as one line + one example of a decision it would force.

# Activity 4 — Three Design Principles

Triads • 45 minutes • Readouts

Convert your audit into 3 design principles your squad can hold the line on.  
Each principle: one line + one decision it would force.

- 10 min: cluster findings into themes
- 15 min: draft 5 candidates
- 10 min: test & cull to 3
- 10 min: write the principle card



10 cluster • 15 draft • 10 cull • 10 write • 90s readouts



# Day 3 Wrap

## What we built

- Shared vocabulary (Nielsen + 3 TPM lenses)
- The 8-check A11y floor
- A severity-scored UX audit
- 3 design principles per triad

## What opens tomorrow

- **Using AI for strategy & research summaries**
- Reuse the Week-1 prompt patterns at strategy scale
- Process the FieldPulse interview + ticket pack

**Bring to Day 4:** Your triad's NS Defense Card, Tier Sheet, and 3 design principles — they all become inputs to AI summarization tomorrow.

# Questions & Reflection

Which of your 3 principles will the design team disagree with most?